



Tern

The Working Holiday Money Kit

Land with your money sorted.

The first-week checklist, the 45% tax trap, your superannuation refund, and the proof-of-funds numbers — everything in one place.

Your first week: the money checklist

Before you fly

- ☐ Open your account before departure — arrive with working account details so your employer can pay you from day one.
- ☐ Have your proof of funds ready as a clean, dated statement (see page 4 for what each country expects).
- ☐ Tell your home bank you're travelling; unblock foreign transactions on your cards.
- ☐ Screenshot/print your visa grant and insurance documents — border officers do ask.

Day 1–2

- ☐ Get a local SIM or eSIM so banks and employers can reach you.
- ☐ Give your employer your local account details (in Australia: BSB + account number).
- ☐ Decline 'pay in your home currency' at every ATM and card machine — that's dynamic currency conversion, often a 5–12% hidden markup.

Week 1

- ☐ Australia: apply for your TFN (free, ato.gov.au) the moment you have an address — without it your employer must withhold 45% tax.
- ☐ New Zealand: get your IRD number — without it you're taxed at the 45% no-notification rate.
- ☐ Canada: apply for your SIN (free) before starting work.
- ☐ Australia: nominate ONE super fund and reuse it for every job — job-hopping creates duplicate funds that quietly eat fees.
- ☐ Keep every payslip from your very first shift (you'll want them for tax refunds — and visa extensions).

The 45% tax trap (and your refund)

Tax is where working holidaymakers quietly lose the most money — first to over-withholding, then by never claiming refunds. The cheat sheet:

Australia

- ☐ No TFN given to your employer = 45% withholding on everything. With a TFN, working holidaymakers pay 15% on the first AUD 45,000.
- ☐ TFN is free and arrives in ~2 weeks. Apply on ato.gov.au — never pay an agent for this.
- ☐ Lodge a tax return after 30 June (or when leaving for good). Average backpacker refund: around \$2,600.
- ☐ Don't let an employer push you onto an ABN for normal wage work — that shifts their tax obligations onto you.

New Zealand

- ☐ No IRD number = 45% no-notification rate. The catch: you need a functioning NZ bank account to get an IRD number — set banking up first.
- ☐ IRD auto-assesses most PAYE workers after the tax year (1 April–31 March); leaving early may need an IR3 return.

Superannuation (Australia) — money people forget

- ☐ Your employer pays 12% of your wage into a super fund on top of your salary. It's yours.
- ☐ When you leave Australia for good, claim it back via DASP. It's taxed at 65% for WHV holders — but 35% of thousands of dollars is still real money.
- ☐ Keep your fund's name, member number and login. Billions sit unclaimed because backpackers lose track.

Rule of thumb

A year of full-time work in Australia often means \$1,500–\$3,500 recoverable between your tax refund and DASP. Treat the paperwork as paid work.

Proof of funds & first-month budget

What immigration expects to see

- ☐ Australia (subclass 417/462): about AUD 5,000, plus evidence you can leave (onward ticket or extra funds).
- ☐ New Zealand: NZD 4,200 minimum, plus an onward ticket or the means to buy one.
- ☐ Canada (IEC): CAD 2,500, plus health insurance covering your whole stay — they can check it at the border.
- ☐ Carry it as a clean, recent bank statement in your name. Screenshots get questioned; formatted statements don't.

A realistic first-month buffer

Budget 2–4 weeks of living costs before your first payday clears: hostel beds, food, SIM, transport, plus a rental bond if you move into a share house. Most travellers land comfortably with the visa minimum plus a month of costs — roughly AUD/NZD 5,000–7,000 all-in.

Where money quietly leaks

- ☐ Airport currency counters (worst rates you'll ever see — exchange nothing there beyond taxi money).
- ☐ Foreign-card ATM fees: \$2–5 per withdrawal plus 1–3% — it compounds fast on cash-heavy farm life.
- ☐ Weekend FX markups on some travel cards.
- ☐ Bank transfers home with a 2–4% margin hidden in the exchange rate. Always compare against the mid-market rate you see on Google.

The fix

Use an account with the real exchange rate, zero ATM fees, and local account details for payday. That's exactly what we're building at Tern — join the waitlist and you're in line from day one.

Go deeper (free guides)

Open an Australian account before you land

whvwithtern.com/en/guides/bank-account-working-holiday-australia

The 45% backpacker tax, in full

whvwithtern.com/en/guides/working-holiday-tax-refund-australia

Claim your super back (DASP), step by step

whvwithtern.com/en/guides/superannuation-refund-dasp

How much money you actually need (AU / NZ / CA)

whvwithtern.com/en/guides/how-much-money-working-holiday-australia

Your first week in Australia: full checklist

whvwithtern.com/en/guides/first-week-money-checklist-australia

Second-year visa: tracking your 88 days

whvwithtern.com/en/blog/second-year-visa-88-days



You're on the list — bring your crew.

Every friend who joins with your link moves you 10 spots up the waitlist. The first 500 become Founding Members.

